mountain, and had been forced to descend about 1000 meters on foot. Stephen, who had fretted about our tardiness, broke out into an enormous smile, and tears came to his eyes, as he saw Jane, Robert, and Lucy enter the dining room where he was poking at his evening meal, unable to eat.

Hawking lost the use of his limbs and then his voice very gradually. In June 1965, when we first met, he walked with a cane and his voice was only slightly shaky. By 1970 he required a four-legged walker. By 1972 he was confined to a motorized wheelchair and had largely lost the ability to write, but he could still feed himself with some ease, and most native English speakers could still understand his speech, though with difficulty. By 1975 he could no longer feed himself, and only people accustomed to his speech could understand it. By 1981 even I was having severe difficulty understanding him unless we were in an absolutely quiet room; only people who were with him a lot could understand with ease. By 1985 his lungs would not remain clear of fluid of their own accord, and he had to have a tracheostomy so they could be cleared regularly by suctioning. The price was high: He completely lost his voice. To compensate, he acquired a computer-driven voice synthesizer with an American accent for which he would apologize sheepishly. He controls the computer by a simple switch clutched in one hand, which he squeezes as a menu of words scrolls by on the computer screen. Grabbing one word after another from the scrolling menu with his switch, he builds up his sentences. It is painfully slow, but effective; he can produce no more than one short sentence per minute, but his sentences are enunciated clearly by the synthesizer, and are often pearls.

As his speech deteriorated, Hawking learned to make every sentence count. He found ways to express his ideas that were clearer and more succinct than the ways he had used in the early years of his disease. With clarity and succinctness of expression came improved clarity of thought, and greater impact on his colleagues—but also a tendency to seem oracular: When he issues a pronouncement on some deep question, we, his colleagues, sometimes cannot be sure, until after much thought and calculation of our own, whether he is just speculating or has strong evidence. He sometimes doesn’t tell us, and we occasionally wonder whether he, with his absolutely unique insights, is playing games with us. He does, after all, still retain a streak of the impishness that made him popular in his undergraduate days at Oxford, and a sense of humor that rarely deserts him, even in times of trial. (Before his tracheostomy, when I